

DIDACTICAL SUPPORT



ANTICIPATION

BEFORE A CRISIS

... how do you make sure the resources you provide are accessible and appropriate to the needs of teaching staff?

... how do you envision and develop new infrastructure flexible enough to be used across units?

Not specifically for the launch of ChatGPT, as we did not anticipate that, but generally, I always tried to make sure that everything we offered could be found very easily and was understandable for all teachers—even for those who didn't have that much experience with didactics, especially in relation to digital teaching. The most important thing for me was to make sure that everyone could develop new innovative courses based on his or her individual skill level. That's why I always invited people to come talk to me at the beginning of every semester, because there is always an opportunity to try something new.



COPING

DURING A CRISIS

... how do you improvise when needs regarding didactical support suddenly change?

This could be really tricky because sometimes people just wanted a quick fix instead of a long-term solution. When this happened, I tried to gently push them towards thinking ahead. First of all, I offered drop-in hours that were originally set up as an emergency support service. However, within this format, it was not always easy to foster long-term developments such as the integration of AI into teaching practices. But that's why we had a weekly AI hour, which was a great way for teaching staff to come together and also share and discuss ideas amongst each other.



ADAPTATION

AFTER A CRISIS ... IS BEFORE A CRISIS

... how do you translate ad-hoc infrastructural solutions into long-term structures?

... how do you adapt your didactical resources to contribute to institutional learning?

The regular drop-in hours have been great to quickly react to teaching staff's needs. What I notice though, is that some questions and challenges come up again and again, so we address these in different resources for staff to download. With the urgent requests dying down, we have now set up a monthly AI clinic, a new format developed after the successful use of the weekly AI hour, where we can dive deeper into ways of integrating AI into teaching – but always with a focus on the didactical side and never just because AI is the new shiny thing.

INFRASTRUCTURE

+ RESOURCES

TECHNICAL SETUP (HARDWARE, SOFTWARE) FOR LEARNING PROCESSES, SPECIALISED TRAINING, TUTORIALS, GUIDELINES

COLLABORATION

+ COMMUNICATION

PROCESSES FOR INTERDISCIPLINARY, MULTI-LEVEL COLLABORATION, LINES OF COMMUNICATION

... with whom do you typically collaborate within and beyond your institution to explore new teaching ideas?

... which communication networks, spaces and channels are useful for you to develop creative solutions for your teaching practice?

I have always had a strong professional network, which I used to explore new ideas. Especially attending conferences – also on AI in teaching – was a great source of inspiration for me. But also within my university, there were always people coming to me with amazing ideas. Sometimes it's the IT department wanting to talk about how a new technology could be implemented in a sound didactical way, sometimes it's professors who were excited to try something new.

... who do you collaborate with to develop ad-hoc didactical solutions to keep teaching processes running?

... how do you communicate didactical support offers so they are usable across the institution?

For me, developing ad-hoc solutions was not that easy. When ChatGPT came out, so many people contacted me and wanted immediate support. While I was happy to help, we needed to establish a booking system for teaching staff to book slots with us. A lot of collaboration of course happened with the IT team. Also, we coordinated very closely which AI tools to use at our university and what additional resources we needed for people to actually be able to use it. The FAQ page we created was a great way to communicate that.

... how do your modes of collaboration change?

... with whom do you engage in critical discussions about which didactical innovations should remain?

Collaboration with teaching staff is probably what has changed the most. It has been really interesting to see how people come to us, actually needing our help – even just because they fear to become obsolete. But also leadership sees us in a new light now and really appreciates our perspectives on how AI can be beneficial for teaching at our university. So, yes, which innovations to keep is a conversation with our president, vice-presidents but also the deans, because they are the ones who need to make sure certain innovations such as digital participation tools come to life in the end.

ROLES

+ RESPONSIBILITIES

INCORPORATION OF PERSPECTIVES, ALLOCATION OF TASKS AND ROLES, DISTRIBUTION OF RESPONSIBILITIES

... what is your role in identifying weaknesses and opportunities of didactical enablement?

... who is involved in proactively exploring avenues for didactical innovations?

In our didactical support unit, we had a very clear structure of responsibilities. Since I was the one always connecting with others at conferences, it was my job to scout trends and look at what's happening at other universities in terms of digital teaching. And then of course, it was not just about scouting but about finding ways to translate these for our university. I even went and looked at our physical classrooms to see how we could change and advance them. But yes, we decided as a team what we want to explore and tried to pilot approaches before rolling them out.

... what is your role in making decisions about didactical adjustments?

... how do responsibilities around creative problem-solving in didactical approaches for teaching shift?

Honestly, I was taking on more of a consulting role when it came to making decisions about didactical adjustments for the entire university. I was always happy to bring in my expertise but at the end of the day, it was not my call. This was difficult, though, because I knew a lot about AI, so of course, leadership wanted me to make decisions. But I didn't actually want that responsibility, because someone would always be unhappy with the decision and I had enough going on to encourage and support teaching staff to rethink their teaching.

... who needs to be involved to ensure that didactical innovations are sustained across the institution?

I am much more often invited to discussion rounds, strategic meetings, committees, etc than before genAI. Every faculty has even assigned one point of contact now to keep us informed on what's happening in their teaching. So that has changed a lot. But making sure that these innovations are sustained is on leadership, not just university leadership but also on my boss. But it's also on the teaching staff – if they don't want to keep improving, we'll have the same lectures we had a hundred years ago.

CONTEXT

REGIONAL AND NATIONAL CONTEXTUAL FACTORS

FOR EXAMPLE: POLICIES AND REGULATIONS, FUNDING, DISCIPLINARY CULTURE, FACULTY GUIDELINES, IT ACCESSIBILITY

How do external conditions influence your creative ability to navigate change?

The pressure is not always easy. I mean, everyone wants quick solutions because teaching staff need to include AI in their teaching and university leadership needs to justify certain decisions to educational politics. If we want to stay up to date, we need to find ways to include AI in our teaching, there are even policies that tell us how to do it. This can be really difficult for me because when that pressure is put on me, it can be hard to keep a cool head to make sure that we still have our focus on didactics and are not just following the trend.

IDENTITY

THE INSTITUTION'S SELF-UNDERSTANDING FOR EXAMPLE: MISSION STATEMENTS, TEACHING CULTURE, SENSE OF BELONGING, ROUTINES AND PRACTICES OF COMMUNICATION AND COLLABORATION

How do the self-understanding of your institution and the corresponding internal dependencies influence your creative ability to navigate change?

We are traditionally more of a brick-and-mortar university. And while COVID did change that a bit, it can be tough to get people to understand that EdTech doesn't necessarily mean that we'll do all our are hesitant towards new things and a bit stuck in their ways. Getting them on board takes a lot of time and patience and doesn't always feel very creative.